Otterly Perfect

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/40180260.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warnings:
No Archive Warnings Apply, Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Entrapta & Scorpia (She-Ra), Catra & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Adora & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Um there's more but it's background

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), all the rest are background/secondary, Entrapta (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Razz (She-Ra), minor OCs

Additional Tags:
Aquariums, Slow Burn, Fluff and Angst, Childhood Trauma, Child Abuse, Abusive Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Lesbian Disaster Adora (She-Ra), Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Catra is Bad at Feelings (She-Ra), First Kiss, Cults, Cuddling & Snuggling, every fic of mine needs cuddling I have decided, Therapy, Crying, Minor Character Death, author is aroace and trying so very hard, Gay, no beta we die like angella, potentially triggering content, no worries I will give a warning per chapter if needed, Reunions, Self-Hatred, Implied/Referenced Self-Harm, Grief/Mourning

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English

Series:
Part 2 of Aquarium go brrr

Stats:
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by sparkystar26888

Summary

Adora has worked at the aquarium for a while now, and is pretty happy with her life. Catra works for a design and installment company, and was just assigned to an aquarium to help with an installation. They haven't talked to or seen each other for over a decade.

Wonder what will happen.

*Changed to M bc of chp 7 mainly

TLDR; trauma, angst, fluff, and slow burn all in one

New Job, Who Dis?

Chapter Notes

> Hi everyone!!! I finally finished this and let me tell you it took so fucking long. I had the idea and was like wow! and then roe v wade hit and then I recovered and I was like I got this! and then techno passed. So that stalled it. But then I needed to study for something and instead I finished this. So.
>
> Uhhhh this is Catra POV and it will flip flop from then on. No TWs I don't think and I would like to say now that I wrote this over like weeks so I prob have plot points I didn't follow up on so no yelling at me please. Also on a reread I think my style of writing changes a bit through out (hopefully for the better), don't be surprised if you see that. Ok enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra hated waking up at 6:30. It wasn't quite that time of spring where it was bright in the mornings, so she just woke up to a dark and honestly kind of musty room. She always felt that she hated the world with a bit more vengeance when she woke up any time before 9 in the morning, and even then a coffee would be needed in order to not break the finger of whoever talked to her. And her alarm, oh lord, her alarm. Every morning its annoying tone would blast through the air, buzzing and buzzing as she forced her eyes open and dragged herself out of the comfort of her bed. Well, as comfortable a bed frame found in the nearby alley could be.

In short, she hated waking up at 6:30 am. But alas, a new assignment had been given to her today, and the building - a freaking aquarium - was like two hours from her apartment. It would not do to start a potentially months-long project by arriving late. Or at least that was the argument that Scorpia used to finally convince Catra to go to bed last night. She was right, of course, but Catra would never admit that out loud. Maybe she should get

her a cheesecake or something as a thank you. Catra thinks that Scorpia likes those; plus, they are relatively cheap.

She stumbled into the cramped kitchen, trying her best to not bang around anything in her search for a decent breakfast. As much as her roommates annoyed her, Catra didn't want to wake them up, especially since Scorpia finally had a day off and Entrapta had just finished a night shift.

Those weren't their real names, but they all preferred nicknames to actual ones. Catra wasn't quite sure she knew their actual names. Was Entrapta's Christine? Or maybe it was Linda. She was pretty sure Scorpia's was Laura or Lauren. In any case, they all felt that their nicknames were more true to themselves than their 'given' names. Plus, they were both with her in the Horde, and knew why she called herself Catra. It was comforting, in a way.

Finally deciding on a bowl of cereal and some orange juice - so she liked to indulge her inner kid sometimes, so what - she sat down to quickly slurp it down. She never knew why she took so long to decide on what to eat, because it was usually the same thing. Anything else in the morning and she could guarantee that she would be feeling sick later on in the day. That was especially not wanted today seeing as it was her first day at this job.

Speaking of which, Catra pulled out her phone to look again at the email sent detailing her job. Catra worked at Hordak Design, Building, and Management, and was a fairly decent employee (despite what her shit salary suggests). It was a little strange as a career choice, considering her upbringing, but was a way to strategize and create things while not doing anything criminal, or, you know, bad in general. She specialized in the design and building of spaces, usually exhibits, which was exactly what she was going to start today. The local aquarium wanted to add an otter exhibit, and hired her company to pick a space and create a "fun, chill, and informative habitat that is created in the otters' best intentions." Fun and chill she could do, but informative might be a stretch. And she'll definitely need some help on making sure the design is good for the otters.

“Shit!” whispered Catra, as she noticed it was already 6:50, and she had to be at the aquarium by 9. She quickly ran to the bathroom to brush her hair and teeth, and jogged to her room to put on the first suit she could find that wasn’t too wrinkled. Grabbing her keys and suitcase, she went out the door and locked it behind her. Catra sprinted down the many flights of stairs - why was the elevator always broken when she needed it? - and skidded out the apartment entrance to see the bus pulling into her stop a block away from her.

Cursing again, she ran as fast as she could, hollering at the bus driver to ‘WAIT! WAIT!’ Thankfully, they seemed to hear her, and she quickly hopped on, paid, and plopped down in a seat, panting. There weren’t many people on the bus yet, and Catra sighed as she leaned back. She dug her phone and earbuds out her bag, and looked out the window at the busy city.

One hour and forty five minutes later, after two bus changes and one very rude squirrel, Catra walked down the sidewalk along the ocean to see the aquarium in the distance. Seeing as it was 8:40, she decided to duck into the public restroom to put on her eyeliner. She usually put on more than this, but she did not have time for the whole shabang. Her classic wings would have to do for today.

Stepping out, she strolled down to the entrance to the aquarium, which, according to the business hours on the door, wouldn’t be open for a little over an hour. Pulling out her phone, she went to her email to try and figure out how she was meant to get inside. Was it someone she was supposed to call, or maybe there was a key somewhere?

Scanning the email, she couldn’t find jackshit, and right when she was about to make a slightly pissed call to her boss, she heard an unfortunately familiar voice shout: “Catra?!?”

Chapter End Notes

That’s chapter one! Ever hear of calm before the storm? Enjoy the emotional normalness for now. Wonder who the voice is lol

All of these chapters are written already so there should be semi regular updates. I think for now it will be every other day bc I’m going on a trip in August and don’t want to drag this out too long.

For those who didn’t read the beginning notes, the POVs will switch every chapter, so next will be Adora. And for those not reading this, be ready for a surprise ig.

Tags will be prob be added as I go, because I forget half the stuff once I write lol. Have a great day!

Meet Cute (Without The Cute)

Chapter Notes

> Hello!! Hope everyone has been doing well! This chapter is Adora POV, and is continuing the exposition for the rest of the story. No TWs this chapter, and some more info has been sprinkled in!
>
> I should mention now that the timeline of this AU is a tad different from the canon. Adora runs away at twelve (in a similar fashion to the beginning of the show), but they haven't reunited until now, and both had zero idea what the other has been up to. More details on the timeline will be revealed later on in the fic, but I thought I would mention this part now!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora loved working at Madame Razz's Magnificent Aquarium, and has for a long time. She had started out as just a volunteer when she was a teenager, and then an intern during college, and now she works full time as the resident aquarist at the MRMA. She even came up with the jingle for the ads: "~Come be a mermaid at M-R-M-A!~". Basically, she loved it.

She and Madame Razz went way back as well. She was one of the first people Adora met when she ran away for the first time, and always opened her doors when Adora was struggling to adjust to her new life with Angella. Not that it was ever like it was with her old foster mom, but it was still hard sometimes. Razz made it easier. Adora owed her a lot.

Which is why she willingly went to work almost two hours early every day. She even went in on the weekends when the animals needed her. Today, though, she was able to sleep in a bit. There was a new exhibit going to be installed starting today, and in exchange for Adora's extensive research and time spent looking

for otters to be shipped in, Razz told her to come in a bit later for a while. For Adora, of course, that means arriving twenty minutes early rather than two hours.

When her alarm went off, she rolled out of bed and quickly got dressed in her uniform, and went to grab a bagel from the kitchen. She put it in the toaster and went to the bathroom to finish getting ready. After buttering her freshly toasted bagel, she left and locked her apartment and took the elevator down to the parking garage.

She was a ten minute drive from the aquarium and fifteen from her adopted parents, and loved to go a bit early to take in the morning air at the pier. Her life was busy, and she hardly got time like this for herself, by herself. During the winter, she would sometimes be able to see the sun rise over the ocean while she drank some coffee. It was wonderful.

Today, though, she only had around ten minutes to relax, and she could see there was already a couple sitting on her usual bench. So instead, she went to one of the railings, and leaned against it to squint at the newly risen sun glinting off the water. There were some fish right below the surface, and she could hear seals barking a little while away. This is why she loved marine animals; the simplicity yet majesty of them all. The delicate yet resistant ecosystem thriving just a stone's throw away.

Sighing, she turned away and walked to the aquarium. As she neared, Adora saw someone in a red suit digging around in a bag at the entrance, seemingly muttering to themself. Getting closer, she started to recognize the person; short with wild brown hair. Wait, is that - "Catra?!?"

The person whipped around, and Adora's breath caught. It was indeed Catra; with her unmistakable yellow and blue eyes, freckles, and nails kept as sharp as claws. "Hey Adora. What the fuck are you doing here?" she asked, and goodness did she sound the same. Raspy voice, playful yet commanding tone. A million memories of the two of them flashed through Adora's mind.

Memories of them laughing as they played countless pranks, hiding together under their beds, and just chatting in the tree outside Shadow Weaver's - what they called their foster mom - house.

"I mean, I can't believe you're here! I work here! I'm the head aquarist; why are you here Catra?" replied Adora, bouncing with excitement. "It feels like it's been years since we last talked, how are you?"

"Yeah, well, it has been years, and that's not my fault, is it," said Catra, who leveled her gaze with Adora's. She immediately stilled, thinking of how they had last parted. Arguing, slamming doors, packing her bag, forcing open their window, the cold, dark streets, the - "Anyways," Catra continued, interrupting Adora's unwelcome trip down memory lane, "I have a temporary job here, and I wasn't informed of how to enter, so. . .."

It took a moment, and then Adora realized what Catra was implying. "Of course! One minute, I have the keys somewhere in my pockets," said Adora, who immediately started digging around her purse. Finding it in one of the many pockets, she whipped out the keys in triumph to show Catra, who looked unimpressed. Smiling nervously, she turned and unlocked the aquarium doors.

They stepped in, and the lights turned on automatically - a feature Adora had suggested and installed a couple years ago. "Welcome to Madam Razz's Magnificent Aquarium!" She exclaimed with her arms wide open, as Catra looked around for what she assumed the first time.

Adora joined her, gazing lovingly at the entrance to one of her favorite places on Earth. The gentle blue and green lights washed over the soothing walls in the huge space, and there was a fish tank in one of the walls where schools of fish milled about. There was the counter where she had worked for a year as an intern, and there were chairs and booths scattered around the room (one where Razz had hosted Glimmer, Bow, and her having their first

shots. Thankfully, the small bit she had spilled could be seen only slightly on one of the cushions). She was, in short, home.

Just as Adora turned to ask Catra a question, the head of management, Joyce, walked through the doors leading to the offices. She had a clipboard in hand - *why did she always have a clipboard? Was there ever anything on it?- and her face broke into a smile upon seeing the two girls. "Oh good, Adora, you're here! One of the turtles over in building B won't eat their breakfast, could you check that out? Oh, and I see you let Elizabeth in! You are Elizabeth, correct?"*

"Yes, it is very nice to meet you in person, Joyce," replied Catra smoothly, and Adora felt utterly confused. Technically she knew that Catra wasn't her real name, just a nickname she chose as kids. But Catra hated her real name with a passion, and used to use it wherever they went. And when was she ever this polite?

"Elizabeth here is to be the head designer, manager, and builder for the new otter exhibit! Quite a big job, but I heard she does very well from the recommendations online, and I sure did love our emails! You two will be working closely some days, so I'm sure you will get to know each other more soon. For now, however, I would love it if you could check out that turtle, Adora, while I show Elizabeth her office and the space where the exhibit would be," explained Joyce, who was looking at Adora with an expression that was practically begging her to leave. Adora wanted to talk with Catra more about so much, but did not feel like making Joyce upset. Despite her snippy attitude on some days, Joyce was genuinely very good at her job, and quite nice most of the time.

So, Adora went to the tunnel that led to building B, as Catra and Joyce turned to go where Joyce had just come from. Right before entering the tunnel, Adora looked back, and saw Catra doing the same. They both whipped their heads back around, and Adora started a brisk pace through the underwater tunnel.

Chapter End Notes

Yoooo chapter two done! I find Adora a bit harder to write, so hopefully this seems at least mostly in character for her. I picked the name Joyce because I couldn't find a SPOP character that fitted this role in the story, and named her after Stranger Things bc I was watching it at the time. No worries, there are only three OCs throughout the story, and they are all minor and because I couldn't find an accurate character for the roles. If that makes sense.

ANYWAYS only small sad this chapter and don't worry it will be ramping up! :) Also in case you were wondering yes the suit Catra is wearing is the Princess Prom one, how did you know?

Have a great day!

Kitchen Hugs

Chapter Notes

> Hey! Chapter three, Catra POV, and we get to see her be an idiot some more! How fun. No TWs this chapter I don't think!
>
> I passed that test that I was studying for earlier so yay for that, and otherwise nothing else to report! Enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Following Joyce down the deceptively long hall, Catra tried but failed at listening to her rambling. She was too focused on whatever the fuck had just happened.

Ever since Adora had run away for the final time, Catra had had countless dreams about them meeting again. Of Catra bumping into Adora on the street, in a shop, or traveling. (Once it was while trying to save Shrek from an army of avocados. She had weird dreams sometimes). Every time, there would be tears, and hugs, and confessions, and then they would hold hands and skip into the sunset. Or something like that. None of her dreams involved swearing at Adora and then immediately guilt-tripping her for leaving an abusive household and then never contacting again because they were both twelve and the system made that hard. If Catra had more self-love and had known that Shadow Weaver should not have been such a bitch to her, she would've left too. Catra doesn't blame Adora, not really. Despite what her younger self had said. Thanks, therapy, for those lovely insights.

Hopefully, the whole "one on one" thing Joyce had mentioned earlier would be coming later in the week, or maybe by some act of God it wouldn't happen at all. As much as Catra wanted to reconnect with Adora, she also wanted to do a good job and focus, which Adora would not help with. Plus, she had to tell Will what was going on, and her next therapy appointment was on Saturday, and today was Monday. How was she going to make it?

“Well, here is your office, Elizabeth! It’s a bit small, I know, but seeing as yours is a temporary position, this is the best we can offer. Everything you need is inside or sent to you in an email! Any questions?” Joyce’s voice yanked Catra back to reality and out of her head. She was silently grateful that she had done projects like this before and knew what to do; she did not want to ask Joyce to repeat everything she must’ve said walking down the hall. Catra shook her head, and Joyce said, “Great! I’ll leave you here for now, and then in around 45 minutes either I or someone on my team will be over to give you a tour of Madame Razz’s. Bye for now!” She gave a small wave, and then walked briskly down the hall.

Catra stepped into her office and looked around. There was a desk in the center back, and there were bookshelves on either side. There was a small window on the back wall, and an office chair and two small chairs in front of the desk. Catra went behind her desk and sat down on slightly uncomfortable cushions, and spun a bit. She unpacked her briefcase, and opened her computer to scan her emails.

After around half an hour of getting set up and settled in, she heard a timid knock on the door. Catra almost didn’t hear it over the sound of her computer whirring (what is up with this thing?), and called out, “Come in!”

The door opened, and a frail man poked his head in. Catra raised her eyebrow, and he stammered out, “Uh, hey! I’m Trevor, I'm here to, uh, show you around?” He had a slightly squeaky voice, and Catra felt he had never done anything against the rules in his life. And honestly? She was ok with that. She kind of liked it.

“Hey Trevor!” replied Catra in a voice that sounded so unlike herself Scorpia would’ve burst out laughing. It was the one she used with customers, and was so feminine sounding and high pitched that most people say they can’t recognize her. She shut her computer and shrugged on her suit jacket, standing up. “Let’s go then!”

Trever smiled shakily and went back into the hallway where Catra followed. He walked down the hall, pointing out different offices and who worked there. She was walking along, mostly uninterested, when Trevor said, “And this is where our head aquarist, Adora, works. I've known her for a long time, she’s pretty nice…” He trailed off as Catra’s attention was piqued, and she looked into the office, as the door was open. It was pretty organized, with various posters of marine animals on the walls. It was much bigger than Catra’s, and was very clearly lived in. It reeked of Adora, and Catra smiled at it, quickly wiping the smile off as soon as she saw Trevor looking at her curiously.

“Cool. So where’s the place where the otter exhibit will be?” Asked Catra, trying to settle back to her indifferent air. Trevor started and then went down the hall and through the entrance room, with Catra around 4 feet behind him. They walked through the tunnel she had seen Adora go through, and Catra looked around in wonder at the fish swimming over and around her. They continued through, passing a shit ton of exhibits with various fish, mammals, and even an octopus. They eventually got to building B, where Trevor stopped at a boarded up door.

“Soo… the exhibit will be past this area, and I think you were given blueprints of the current design? I think it used to be some offices, which is why the door is so small. I think that will be part of your changes?” Asked Trevor, who was twisting his hands.

“Yeah, I did, and I saw the door on the blueprints. I have a couple questions about the pipes and basic infrastructure of the northwest corner of the space, is there someone I could speak to…” Catra trailed off as she saw Adora across the space. She had just turned around, and waved eagerly at her. She started to come over, and Catra panicked, saying, “Actually, Trev, could we just go in there now? I need to inspect some things.”

“Trev. . .? Uh, yeah, I think we have clearance? If you come over here, there is an entrance for some employees,” replied Trevor, who started towards the opposite direction that Adora was. Catra

turned, feeling kind of guilty, but also grateful that she wouldn't have to deal with her yet. She wasn’t ready.

She could somehow imagine the devastation on Adora’s face. It hurt.

It turns out, she hadn’t been ready the entire day. She didn’t have to talk to Adora professionally for at least a week as Catra figured out demolishing and budgeting, so it wasn’t necessary yet. And Catra kept repeating that to herself as she continuously ignored and ran from Adora who was somehow everywhere she went. Yeah, it was just her being a coward, but it was easier with an excuse. She didn’t want to get angry again, or worse, she didn’t want to cry. There was no guarantee of how it would go, and she was definitely not ready to find out. So, she ignored Adora.

When she finally got home, she flopped down on her creaky couch in exhaustion. She’s pretty sure Entrapta just woke up, and so wanted to wait to say bye before she left and before Catra hopped in the shower. Scorpia had gone out on a run, and the cheesecake Catra had picked up for her was chilling in the fridge. Catra rubbed at her eyes, and went to her calendar to double check her therapist appointment. Adora was sure to trigger some bad shit, not on purpose of course, but she was associated with awful memories. Plue, she could tell that her mental health was already deteriorating. Maybe she should up her appointments up to twice a week? But will she have the money . . . ?

“CATRA! You’re home! Thank goodness, I almost burnt down the kitchen trying to make scrambled eggs earlier! Could you help? I got distracted by stuff in my room, and then fell asleep again,” said Entrapta, who shook Catra out of her musing. She smiled, and looked over at the sink, finally identifying the weird black stuff she had seen earlier. Pulling out a pan and some eggs, she got to work while listening to Entrapta’s ramblings. She was always more talkative this time of day.

“And then Scorpia told me about her weird dreams, and oh boy! you should hear it. Oh! How was your first day at the new place?

It’s an aquarium, right?” Asked Entrapta, who was bouncing up and down on her stool.

“Yeah, it’s pretty nice,” she paused, wondering if she should tell Entrapta about Adora. They had never met, but she had heard countless stories about Adora late at night - usually when Catra was trying not to break down and needed to focus on something positive. It didn’t always work, but it was nice. “Um, Adora works there, apparently. The head aquarist, whatever that is.”

“Oh,” replied Entrapta. She stilled for a second, then asked gently, “How are you?”

“Honestly? Could be better, could be worse. I plan on telling Will. I’m just avoiding her until then, you know?” Catra gave a half-hearted chuckle, and then it was silent for a bit. Entrapta came over, and gave her a hug. Catra stopped in surprise. Entrapta wasn’t big on physical touch, and a hug was rare. It was awkward, but nice.

“I hope you guys get close again. I know how much you loved her,” said Entrapta quietly. “Try to be nice to her, though. Speaking from experience, avoiding people does not make them like you. They just think you’re weird.”

“Thanks, Trap. I don’t think you’re weird. I mean, you are, but the lovable weird. Those other people were assholes, I hope you know,” replied Catra. They hugged in silence for a second, and then Entrapta pulled away. They chatted for a bit longer as Entrapta ate her eggs, and then Scorpia came home and they all had a slice of cheesecake. Entrapta left for work, and Scorpia and Catra sat together on the couch, eating their dinner, talking, and watching tv.

She missed Adora, but it was nice knowing that she had a family who would never leave her. They loved her, and she loved them. A lot.

Chapter End Notes

Entrapta my beloved! Also, Trevor is named after the Trevor Project (which you guys should check out and support) and is aroace because I am and I say so. Will is also named after Stranger Things bc brainrot. That's it for now, and I hope you all have a great day!

Also, please comment puns. I love them so very much :)

I'm An Ally!

Chapter Notes

> Hi hi hi!! Sorry this is a tad late, I forgor. No TWs today, and this is in Adora POV! Get ready for lesbian dumbassery /pos.
>
> On a personal note, I've been learning how to swallow pills for medical reasons, and I can proudly say I can swallow a mini m&m first try without crying now. Leveling up!!
>
> Hope you all enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

God, Adora had forgotten how awkward Catra could be. It had been two weeks, because Catra had found an issue with the plumbing, and so them meeting had been pushed back. In the inbetween, Adora had tried unsuccessfully to catch Catra to talk to her. Every time she tried, Catra would find a convenient excuse to find somewhere else to be. It was annoying, but she kind of understood. They hadn't left each other on the best of terms, and it had been so long that Catra probably had started hating her.

Other than the surprise of Catra showing up, everything had been pretty normal. The turtle had been ok, just a picky eater as usual. It wasn't too busy, but she did have to start preparing the animals for the end of school year. Most schools had aquarium field trips around this time, and some animals had to go to different areas to not be bothered by any unruly children. If she were being honest, Adora didn't love when schools came to the aquarium. The animals usually became stressed, and so did she as she tried to keep all the animals healthy and calm. She knew that the kids loved it, but she wished the chaperones actually, like, chaperoned. Usually they just took pictures and stood around.

There was a group coming by the end of the week, and Adora was slowly getting ready for the craziness that was about to occur. It left little room to try and talk to Catra, but she still attempted it

whenever she could. In the break room, in the halls, trying to get to her from across the room. She would get so close to her, almost close enough to touch her (close enough to hug her). But then Catra would see her, and she would get this scared look in her eyes, and she would turn and leave.

"What's with the gloomy face, Dora?" Spinnerella's voice jolted Adora out of her musing over Catra. Spinnerella was a nickname that Adora had given when she was a teen. At the time, she had done it because it had reminded her of when she would do that with Catra. Spin had never let her forget it, and would occasionally introduce herself to others as it. So did some of the others. It was funny, and always left Adora with a warm feeling.

"Oh, nothing. Worried about the school group later, you know?" Adora shrugged, trying to keep her voice light.

"Oh, I get what you mean. They make taking inventory at the gift shop so frustrating. I hope some of the summer workers from last year come back, they were great," sighed Spinnerella wistfully. Adora chuckled, and went back to her computer. She usually worked out in the break room, finding her office too isolating. "Well, hey there!" Adora looked up as Spin greeted whoever just walked in.

"Hey. Hey, Adora. Our first meeting will be in 30 minutes. Could you come to my office? It's down hall D," said Catra. Whipping her head around, she saw Catra standing there in another pretty suit, with a hand on her hip.

Adora stammered out, "Uh, yeah! For - for sure! 30 minutes sounds great! Ha. see you then, I guess!" She felt her face go pink, and she saw Catra's face go a little red as well before she spun around and went back through the door. Adora turned to face the table, and put her head in her hands. "God . . ." she whispered.

"You know," started Spinnerella, who had plopped down in the seat next to Adora with a mischievous smile, "Netossa said she

spotted a mini lesbian flag on the new girl's desk."

"So?"

"So, you have a chance to turn this flustered mess into an actual thing," replied Spin, who had an eyebrow raised.

"What?! No no no, we were friends as kids! I never saw her that way . . . plus, isn't dating coworkers like against the rules?" asked Adora. She was slightly lying about the first part, but Razz had given her many talks about the second. Spin and Netossa were the only exceptions Razz had ever made for her no dating policy. The two were just too cute together, and worked well. Plus, the wedding at the aquarium had been really darn cute.

"Woah there! Who said anything about dating?" said Spin, who was smiling far too much for Adora's liking. "Although, I hear she's a temporary hire."

"I don't see her in that way, Spin," insisted Adora. She loved her friend, but knew that she was one of the biggest gossips at work. If Adora didn't damp this down now, who knows what would happen.

"Alright, alright," said Spin, raising her hands in surrender as she got up. She turned to leave, as Adora got herself prepared for her meeting. "Just remember, Adora. A lot can happen in a couple months." Spinnerella winked, and then walked out the door.

Adora got to the meeting ten minutes early. She had been standing outside the door for what felt like forever, just trying to muster up the courage to knock and be let in. Maybe she could leave, and then when Catra emailed her later asking what happened she could say that there was an emergency or something. Like, a fire.

She shook her head, took a deep breath, and then lightly tapped on the door, half hoping that Catra wouldn't hear it. "Come in!" Shit, she heard it. Adora cracked open the door and stepped inside to see Catra sifting through papers behind her desk.

Wow, was this office a mess. Adora looked around at the stacks of paper everywhere and the overflowing shelves and drawers. Even in their youth Catra was never an organized person, but Adora had just thought it was a phase. Apparently it had just gotten worse.

"Go ahead and sit, I just have to pull something up on my computer," said Catra, and Adora gingerly sat in the seat on the other side of the desk. They sat in an awkward silence for a minute, and then they both spoke.

"Alright so I-"

"How have you-" They both stopped, laughing nervously. Adora spoke up and said, "Um, you can go first."

Catra looked her in the eyes. It was intense, but Adora found she couldn't look away. "Thanks. I was going to say, that, uh, I know that it's been forever and that I've been avoiding you, and I wanted to say sorry for that last part. I was nervous, you know? It's been a long time, and what I said to you that first day was far out of pocket. I know it wasn't your fault." Catra paused, and broke eye contact to look down at her hands. "We were different people then. Kids. A lot was going on. Because of that, I think we should get everything emotional out of the way before we get to work."

"I agree."

"Do you want to go first?"

"Oh! Yeah, sure," responded Adora, and suddenly found that every thought that she had ever had had left her mind. She scrambled, and said, "So, women, huh." Mentally, she smacked herself in the forehead. That was definitely NOT what she had wanted to say. "I mean like that's cool and everything. I'm an ally! Wait, no I'm not. I mean, I am, because I'm also a lesbian, so like, that makes me an immediate ally, you know?" Adora could feel her face burning red.

So was Catra's, who shifted and said, "Yeah. I know."

There was some more silence, and Adora finally figured out what to say. "I'm sorry I left." Catra started to open her mouth, and Adora pushed on. "I know, I know, we were kids, and it was a crappy situation. But I should have, I don't know, talked to you before running away for the last time. It's just, I knew my now adoptive mom would take me in, and I couldn't stand being there anymore. We were 12; I wasn't thinking about what Shadow Weaver might've done to the rest of you. To you. I just had to leave. I hope you know that every day since I left I have thought about you. I'm so sorry." Adora could feel tears welling up in her eyes, and she brought her hand up to wipe them away.

"Adora, hey. It's ok. I get it now. You're right. We were kids, in a shitty situation, and if I had realized just how bad it was when I was younger, I probably would've left too. But I go to therapy now, and I'm healing," said Catra, who was smiling gently at Adora. Adora smiled back. "And I missed you too."

"Well, maybe we could get closer over this project, huh?" Suggested Adora, and Catra gave a quick smile before getting serious again.

"Right, well, first I need you to tell me the necessary things for this exhibit and how much they would cost. I looked through the file you put together, and . . ." Catra and Adora's meeting took the rest of the working day, and by the end they were both smiling and chatting like old times. Well, not quite like old times. They both still had scars, and some of the laughter was strained, but Adora could see it getting better. She hoped it would get better.

Chapter End Notes

> Yay! The girls are getting past the icebreaker stage! Now kiss! /j, that won't be happening for a while. Also ignore the tags, they give spoilers to some of the angst hehe. And I added the turtle line in case anyone was concerned.

I have a couple different ideas rn for later works, but seeing as I'm going on a trip in August we will see how much I actually do. BUT one is really angsty and I could prob do as a one shot so we'll see what happens.

Catra next (how fun), and I hope you all have lovely days!

Therapy 101: Tears, Fears, and Queers

Chapter Notes

> Hello!! Today we see more of Catra and Adora, and Catra going to therapy. Very slight TWs this chapter, as Catra and Will both refrence past trauma a couple times. Nothing too explicit, though. Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The next couple weeks were definitely much better than the first two. They had broken ground a bit ago, and so far the exhibit had been right on schedule. She and Adora talked more days than not, and slowly they were rebuilding their friendship.

Catra remembered when they were younger, and how they could sit together in silence for hours, or walk around their neighborhood the whole day and never get bored. She knew that that was a time that was long gone, and a lot of their activities were just to escape their foster mom. When they were younger, they gave each other fake names. Will says that it was a way to escape from their reality; to make everything look prettier than it actually was. When he first said that, Catra had scoffed in disbelief. But they did not call their foster mom "Shadow Weaver" because of her sunny disposition.

It was coined the first night she had sent them to bed without dinner. She was pretty sure it was for accidentally spilling water. Adora had gotten off with a stern talk, but Catra had been dragged to the basement, and Adora had protested so much that she had been put down there with her. Their foster mom had cut the light to the basement long ago, and so they coined her Shadow Weaver, and made every shadow that scared them just one of her henchmen. Catra was pretty sure they had been five.

So Catra did not want the exact same relationship she and Adora had had, because it was one built out of necessity, and trauma.

Now, they had a chance to make a friendship like two normal adults do. They could chat about the weather, and create inside jokes based on their project, and Catra could stare at Adora's face a bit longer than she should've. You know. Normal adult friendships.

They often took lunch break together, and were sitting on one of the benches outside looking over the ocean. It was slightly windy, but sunny enough that they were both in tshirts. As the days wore on, Catra had become less concerned with wearing professional clothes, if some of the outfits she had seen the employees wear gave any indication of the dress code. Catra was sipping coffee, and Adora was rambling on about one of the jellyfish while occasionally taking big bits of her sandwich.

Catra loved when she did this, and would just watch Adora talk animatedly for however long their break was. She was doing that now, with a small smile on her face. Adora took a second to take a break, and glanced at Catra. "What's up, Catra? You're just staring at me, am I talking too much?"

"No, no!" hurried Catra. Fuck, why was she staring at her? "You just have something on your face. Here, let me just. . ." Catra reached her hand out and wiped a crumb off of Adora's top lip, which she had noticed a bit ago. Her hand lingered as she noticed just how soft Adora's lip was. They locked eyes, and Adora's were beautiful and wide. Catra cleared her throat and took her hand away, sipping her coffee while keeping her gaze fixed on the horizon.

They were quiet for a bit, and then Adora asked, "So, any plans after work today?"

"Uh, yeah, actually. I have to go see my therapist, Will," said Catra. While it had been great getting closer to Adora, it was also hard for her as sometimes bad memories or thoughts would be triggered. As a result, Catra had gotten enough money scraped together to have two appointments a week; one still on Saturdays, and one on Wednesdays.

“Oh, cool. Is he a good therapist? Do you like him?”

“Yeah, he’s great. Do you go to therapy?”

“No, I don’t have any reason to,” responded Adora. Now that was some bull if Catra had ever heard any. Even if Shadow Weaver had never gotten physical with Adora like she did Catra, she was still a bitch to her, and Adora being on the streets so often surely had affected her.

“You don’t have to have a reason for therapy, you know. There’s not like a checkpoint you have to reach in order to be like ‘whelp, I’m bad enough for therapy!’ You can go for anything.”

“Well, that’s great, but I don’t need it. Ok?” snapped Adora, and Catra fell silent. “Look, I’m sorry for snapping, but I am truly ok. I promise.”

“Alright then,” sighed Catra. Something she had never forgotten was what Adora sounded like when she was lying or being defensive. But one of the most important aspects of therapy is that you accept that you need or want it, and Catra did not feel like trying to push Adora into any realizations right now. Right now, she just wanted her happy. “So, Bob the jellyfish keeps trying to escape? How does a jellyfish do that, exactly?”

Adora’s face lit up, and she went back into her ranting. Catra settled in, and tried not to worry about her friend too much.

—

Screw it. She was worried. She really wanted to trust that Adora was ok, but she was so self-sacrificing that Catra knew that Adora would never tell anyone if she was struggling. Which is exactly how she presented her dilemma.

“So, let me get this right. You want your old friend, whom you haven’t seen since you were both twelve and in a foster home run by a woman in a cult who abused both of you to the point where your friend ran away multiple times, to go to therapy right now,

even though you yourself only started seeing me because your friends insisted. AND during the first few meetings refused to talk to me until we played a game of pictionary and you got competitive," said Will.

"Yes."

"Catra." Will was the only non-friend who ever called her Catra, because he never judged her for it and she liked that name more, so he had to "respect her" or something. She didn't mind. "You took forever to admit to needing therapy. And it was recommended to you by friends who grew up with you and in the same environment, and you trust your life with. She has not known you for over a decade, and you two grew up in that time in different spaces. Getting her to trust your therapy recommendation when she barely knows the adult you is going to take some time. Additionally, from what I heard, she has very set ideas about what parameters are needed for therapeutic help, which will have to be changed before even attempting to convince her of her own needs."

"I hate when you are smart about things," said Catra, crossing her arms.

"Yes, well, it's a curse and a blessing," said Will. Catra snorted. "But, it does sound like you two are getting closer. What are our feelings on that?"

"I don't know. I mean, I'm grateful for it, obviously, but . . ." Catra trailed off, unsure of how to put her feelings into words.

"But?" Prompted Will.

"But I am just remembering so many things from our childhood, and how badly I treated her sometimes. I mean, who wants to stay friends with a person like that, you know?" Catra hadn't even realized she felt that way until just now, but it was true. She was a bitch as a kid, and Adora never deserved that. "I never deserved Adora."

“Well, let’s think about that. You were both kids, growing up in a hellish situation. Taught certain things about the world, and taught to be cruel. You were products of your environment. But you both grew. You both escaped. Those types of thoughts will send you deeper into a self-hatred spiral, and I think we both would rather that not happen again. So, let’s come up with two plans. One can be for trying to show Adora that therapy can be for anyone, and the other can be a plan to apologize to both her and yourself for what has happened.” Catra enjoyed when Will took charge like this during therapy, because when she got emotional, she made awful plans and decisions.

Although some of his plans made no sense. “Why would I apologize to myself?”

“Because you need to forgive yourself for things out of your control. It is the next step in healing, and I think you are ready for it. What do you think?” Catra was silent for a bit, thinking. Maybe Will was right. Maybe she was holding grudges against herself for what she had done as a kid, as a teen.

Hell, she might as well give it a shot. “Fine. What’s the first step?”

Chapter End Notes

> We finally meet Will, who is very very good. I have gone to therapy myself, and the feelings Catra has about therapists being too smart is in fact accurate.
>
> You may be thinking that Catra had already worked through some of these doubts and self hatred, and she probably has! But recovery or progress is not linear, and everyone has missteps, especially around change or something new.
>
> Have a great day!

Under The Jellyfish

Chapter Notes

> Hey! Adora POV (my beloved), and this is a fairly chill chapter, with slight TWs referencing past criminal activity and Shadow Weaver being a stalker (and a bitch). Nothing graphic, all refrences, so I think it should all be good!
>
> Also, chapter title should be read in the same tune as "Under the Sea" from Little Mermaid.
>
> Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Often, Adora stayed at the aquarium pretty late. She would have to make her rounds, checking up on all the fish and various animals, making sure they were all safe and healthy before she closed up. Razz would sometimes be there, and they would talk late into the night about a variety of things. The aquarium was simply peaceful at night; the sounds of running water and the low lights would bring an atmosphere Adora could find nowhere else.

This was one of those nights, where she had stayed behind to check up on some fish in building C. She was walking around, checking on every tank, when she got to building B, where the jellyfish exhibit was. It was one of her favorites, because it was like a loop you could walk into. Part of it went under the floor, and then one could stand there and watch as the jellyfish went around and around. Often, it had different colored lights, too, and that at night gave her indescribable calmness.

This was where she found Catra tonight. She was sitting in the loop, her arms wrapped around on knee and her eyes transfixed on the jellyfish above her. Adora sat down next to her, and leaned her head against her shoulder. They sat like that in silence for a couple minutes, the only sounds being each other's breath and the running water of the tanks.

“I like to come here at night sometimes,” whispered Catra. “It’s peaceful.”

“Yeah, it is,” Adora whispered back.

“Especially when the past bugs me too much. It brings a certain type of quiet, you know?”

“Yeah, I do. Sometimes memories get a bit loud,” agreed Adora.

“That’s why I go to therapy. Will helps me make the past quieter,” continued Catra.

Adora hummed in agreement, unsure of what to say. For some reason, therapy had always been a terrifying thought to her; it had surprised her to learn that Catra of all people had started going. It seemed like it helped, though.

They leaned against each other for a while longer, until Adora felt the sudden need to fill the silence. “I’ve been meaning to ask. How’d you get into design? I mean, how did you leave Shadow Weaver in the first place?” She felt Catra stiffen, and rushed to say, “Of course, you don’t have to tell me if you don’t want to. I don’t want you to feel uncomfortable.”

“No, no, it’s fine. It’s a bit of a story though; you sure you want to hear it?”

“Yes.”

“Alright, then.” Catra shifted a bit, thought for a moment, and then took a deep breath. “When you ran away for the last time, Shadow Weaver was pissed. Like, next level angry. She fought hard to try and get you back. When she couldn’t, she took her anger out on us. Made us learn how to fight, how to shoot a gun. You know that cult she was a part of, the Horde? Yeah, she made us all “official” members. Had us stealing, breaking and entering, kidnapping. Stuff that I don’t even want to talk about. All in the name of the Horde, the group destined to save the world from evil. By the time I was 17, I was planning half these things. I

thought I was right and justified in what I did. I was angry, and lonely, and Shadow Weaver expected nothing short of perfection. It was bad."

Catra had paused, and Adora tried to take it all in. Shadow Weaver had definitely tried indoctrination when she was there, and that was part of the reason she ran away - both times. But actually doing it? She couldn't even imagine what it was like. "How did you get out?"

"I got arrested." Adora looked at Catra in surprise. She shrugged, and said, "It was for something stupid, too. I was at the scene of a drug exchange, and they arrested me as an accomplice. I was just walking by, but I had the Horde jacket on, and apparently that was one of the groups involved. All the crimes I committed, and that's what they got me for."

"What happened?"

"Well, I was still a minor, so Shadow Weaver was called, because she was my legal guardian. She was able to pull some strings and get me out. But while I was there, I met this girl. I don't remember why she was arrested, but I think it was something petty. Anyways, we talked, and she helped me realize I wasn't thinking for myself. That I didn't really want any of what I was doing. So, after I was released, I started looking into colleges. Thought to major in design and minor in accounting because I enjoyed the strategy. It was a place to be creative but not criminal. Picked up stuff about mechanics, and got the job at Hordak. Ran by the estranged son of the head of Horde, weirdly enough. Got one of my other friends out - Scorpia, remember her? - and the minute I turned 18 I was out of there. Went to a community college outside the city and never looked back. It wasn't the best, but anything was better than staying with that bitch." Catra and Adora sat in silence for a bit, as Adora tried to digest all she had just learned.

“Did you go to an actual college afterwards, or . . .?” Adora didn’t know much about community college, but she was pretty sure what you could get there wasn’t enough for the type of jobs Catra did.

“No, because I didn’t have the money for it and honestly didn’t want to go.”

“I just don’t get how-”

“What, how I could get a job like this? Well, I did, princess. I may have gone to a shitty community college and you to a fancy ass university, but remember that we are still both working here. So, keep the judgment to yourself, thanks,” Catra retorted, shifting in a way in which her back was to Adora.

Adora scrambled and said, “No, no, I just. Was wondering, that’s all. I’m sorry.”

Catra sighed, and said, “It’s fine. I’m sorry for lashing out like that. I was right, but there was probably a better way to say it.” Catra went back to leaning against Adora.

“Wow, insightful.”

“Yeah, that’s what therapy gets you. A backbone and common sense.” Adora smiled, and they watched the jellyfish slowly move up and down, the lights changing gently. She wasn’t sure how long they had sat there before Catra asked a question. “So, what happened after you ran away that last time?”

“Well, I went to a friend I had made last time I ran away; a girl called Glimmer.”

“Really, Glimmer?”

“Alright, Catra.”

“Fair enough, continue.”

“When I met her, she didn’t believe my name was actually Adora and so chose Glimmer as a way to mock me. She realized soon after I was telling the truth, but the name stuck. Anyways, I went to her and her parents. They took me in, and then fought to adopt me. They won, but then. Well. Shadow Weaver kept trying to find me. She would watch me while me and my friends were out. Try to get people from the Horde to get me. At one point, she even broke in.”

“What?” Catra turned to look at Adora in surprise.

“Yeah, it was terrifying. We couldn’t get a restraining order because of how far Shadow Weaver’s influence spread, so we had to move. I made some new friends, and from then on, we weren’t really excited about going back to where Shadow Weaver was. So I grew up; I went to high school, then college, then came to work here again. The first time I ran from Shadow Weaver, I got far. I ended up staying with Razz until the system took me back, and when we moved into the area I decided to continue coming here. It’s like home to me,” whispered Adora, and she felt a weight off her chest. She left a few of the darker details out, and glossed over a few things, but it was all the truth. And it felt nice to tell someone the truth.

“Well, I’m glad,” whispered Catra. “I’m glad you got out, and found this place. I’m glad you’re happy.” Adora felt overwhelmed, and enveloped Catra in a hug. She stiffened, but then sank into the hug as Adora squeezed. They stayed like that for a while.

“Hey, it’s kind of late. Have you had dinner yet?” Asked Adora.

“No. Have you?”

“No. Want to come to my place and we can make some dinner?” Adora closed her eyes, not wanting to see Catra’s expression. Was it too soon to ask this? What if Catra thought she was weird? What if-

“Yeah, sure. Let’s get going,” replied Catra, who stood up and stretched.

Adora smiled, and then remembered. “Oh, shoot. There’s no room on my street anymore for non-residential cars. Maybe there’s a parking lot nearby where you could leave your car?”

“I take public transportation, so there’s no problem there. Let me text my roommates and tell them I’ll be later than usual and grab my stuff from my office, then I’ll be good to go. Meet at the entrance?” Catra looked up at Adora with hopeful eyes and a gentle smile. In the dim room, the only lights were from the jellyfish tank. They illuminated one side of Catra’s face, leaving the other only slightly visible. She was wearing her usual suit, and she had let her hair free and wild today. Adora had never seen a more beautiful sight.

“Yeah, sure. I’ll meet you there.”

Chapter End Notes

> Yay!! Talking!! Adora is so very gay for Catra; if only she could realize it. Also on my reread through I've realized I haven't made a lot of marine puns (like only one) and I am so sad for the missed opportunities. Damn the plot /j. Some more backstory revealed; I've tried to stick to canon in terms of events.
>
> ALSO the jellyfish exhibit is based off the one in the Seattle Aquarium, which I saw once and have loved for forever. Finally, I am working on another oneshot surrounding these two, also marine themed for some reason (and also sad).
>
> Have a great day!!

Mac and Cheese, Cuddles, and Crying

Chapter Notes

> Hello everyone! This chapter is one of the most intense ones of the whole fic. TWs for graphic child abuse, and mention of self harm. If you want to skip, it starts at "and it brought her some comfort" and ends at "As Catra's crying grew softer". I will give a summary in the end notes. Please stay safe, and lmk if I need to adjust the TWs!
>
> Enjoy the chapter

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Fuck, Catra was nervous. The entire walk to wherever Adora lived - and she couldn't believe Adora lived in walking distance - Catra had just let Adora ramble. She felt bad for her one to two word answers, but it was all she could do as she prepared herself for spending one on one time with Adora for who knows how long. In a non-professional setting, no less. She hoped to whoever was above that she wouldn't say something insanely stupid, or make a fool of herself. Adora had had a look on her face when Catra mentioned her roommates that indicated clearly that she had almost never had to live with someone other than family. At least that meant that she and Adora would be alone.

Catra wasn't sure if that was a good or bad thing.

"Whelp, here we are! Follow me!" exclaimed Adora, stopping in front of an apartment building. They went in, and Catra tried not to look around in amazement. The lobby was much nicer and cleaner than Catra's ever was. Elevators were never broken for long here, it seems.

That was proven almost immediately as Adora beelined to one of the 2 (two!) lobby elevators and popped inside. Catra joined her slowly, wary of the elevator's stability.

Adora laughed. “Are you scared of elevators?”

“Look, I’ve had bad experiences, alright?” responded Catra.

Adora giggled, and pressed the five button. “I promise this is safe, kitten.”

“Kitten?” Catra looked at Adora in mock anger.

“Yep! Awh, look at the wittle kitty-witty,” Adora said, and then started making baby noises while trying to pet Catra. Catra hopped around the elevator to avoid her pets, hissing and insisting on her humanness. By the time they had reached the fifth floor, they were both out of breath and laughing.

“See!” gasped Adora. “Not so bad after all, huh?”

“Yeah, yeah, ok weirdo,” replied Catra, grinning. They stepped out and went down the hall, Adora stopping at room 5C.

She unlocked the door, and swung it wide. “Welcome, to the Adora Abode.” Catra stepped in after her, and this time Catra couldn’t hold back her wonder as she looked around. Adora’s apartment was, to put it lightly, huge. Not to say that her own wasn’t a decent size, but that was for three people. Adora lived alone, and the living room/kitchen area was twice the size of Catra’s. Everything looked clean and slightly expensive, yet also it was very clear that Adora lived here. There was a stack of books on the coffee table, a wall of weird and personal mugs in the kitchen, and she could see a pile of clothes on the couch that Adora was trying unsuccessfully to chuck under the couch.

“Sorry for the mess,” chuckled Adora, “I wasn’t really expecting to bring anyone home tonight.” Catra raised an eyebrow at that, and Adora reddened. “Not like that! No, no, I just meant like I didn’t expect to have anyone over! Or, or like have a night guest! I mean a guest at night! I mean-” As Adora spoke, she got progressively redder and redder and more flustered.

“Adora, relax. What you do at night is none of my business,” interrupted Catra, who then winked and turned away to go into the kitchen as Adora sputtered. “So, what’s for dinner?”

Dinner turned out to be some boxed macaroni and cheese and rolls of deli meat from Adora’s fridge. They laughed and talked, and might have had a few glasses of wine. They ended up on the couch, snuggling and talking about random things. There was a lull of slightly drunken silence, when Adora asked, “Earlier, you said that when I left Shadow Weaver was mad at you.”

“Yeah?”

“Did she . . . do anything? To you?”

Catra stiffened, and answered cautiously. “Yeah.”

“Like what? If you want to say, of course.” Catra’s heart started racing. Shadow Weaver was always a bitch to her, but it got much worse when Adora left. Especially in the early days, when Catra was less able to stand up for herself.

“I can tell you, but it’s not pretty.” *Not like you, Catra’s tipsy mind thought.*

“I can handle it.” Adora squeezed Catra tightly, and it brought her some comfort.

She took a deep breath, closed her eyes, and opened her mouth. "When she first found out you were gone - and I mean the very first time - she was pissed. She went around and yelled at everyone, and kicked me out on the street to go find you. When it got dark, I begged her to let me back in. You know how terrified of the dark I was. She wouldn’t. Not until I found you.” She had banged on the door so hard, there were dark red stains left on it that could only be covered up by paint. Two coats of it. She still had nightmares from that night. Walking down the sidewalk in the pitch black, holding her bleeding knuckles close to her. "When I finally brought you back, she took me into the bathroom, and hugged me in gratitude. She had never done that before.

"When you left the second time a year later, and I came back empty handed? She threw me into the basement. I was left down there for three days, I think. No food, no water, no bed, no bathrooms. Just me and the dank, dark, terrifying basement." Adora drew her closer, and Catra squeezed her eyes even tighter to try to not let the tears come spilling out. "When she finally came down there, I was so happy to see her. I tried to hug her. She slapped me away. She would say awful things to me, and then every time I spoke up or protested, she would hit me. Eventually, she took out a taser." Adora gasped. Tears started streaming down Catra's face, and she found she didn't care enough to wipe them away.

"She would say I was worthless, pathetic, useless. And when I did anything, when I tried anything to get her to stop, she would taze me. It hurt. It was like lightning, focused on a single part of my body." When Catra had gotten older, she would try to hide those scars with some of her own creation. Will had finally helped her stop two years ago. "She would yell at me to stop crying, and it would just make me cry harder. I fell unconscious at one point, and she woke me up with a slap to the face." Catra stopped, sobbing into Adora's chest, who had remained mostly silent until now.

Catra came to a lull in her crying, and whispered, "I stayed in the basement for a week. That was the worst thing she ever did to me." Other things had gone on that week, but only Will would ever know what they were. It was mostly more of the same, anyways. No one had to know.

As Catra's crying grew softer, Adora, keeping her grip tight around Catra, said quietly, "I - I don't understand. Had she hit you before?"

"Yes," she whispered. "You were just always in the other room. She made sure you never knew."

"I am so sorry, Catra," Adora whispered to her. "I'm sorry I left you with her. I'm sorry for . . . for everything."

"It's ok, Adora," Catra whispered back. "I never wanted you to know. You did what you had to."

"It's not ok," said Adora. "What she did to you was not ok, and I need you to know that, Catra. Catra, do you hear me? That was not ok."

"I know, Adora. I know," soothed Catra. She wrapped her arms around Adora, and they stayed wrapped in each other's embrace for a very long time.

"Hey, Catra, are you still awake?" whispered Adora.

Catra will admit, the crying had tired her out, and she had been dozing a bit, but Adora didn't need to know that. "Yeah, of course I am, princess."

"Want some water?"

"Sure." Catra watched as Adora got up, stretched, and walked over to her kitchen. She felt a longing for Adora's warmth, and slight sadness to see her go.

"Oh! Want to play a video game?" Adora plopped back down on the couch after handing Catra a glass of water. Catra drank thankfully, and looked at her with curiosity. "It'll be a great distraction! Plus, I want to see if I'm actually good at the games, or if Glimmer and Bow are just trash at video games."

"Bow? What kinda stupid ass name is that?"

"Hey! When he heard I called Glimmer, well, Glimmer, he wanted a name too!"

"And Bow was the best you came up with?"

"He takes archery! Plus, we met him when we moved. I didn't know him well enough for an awesome name like Catra," Adora smiled brightly at Catra, and Catra felt herself blush slightly. "So, is that a yes?"

Catra thought about it, then shrugged. "Fuck it, why not. You need someone to take your ego down a peg anyways."

Adora made a mock offended face, and then hooked everything up - it was a multiplayer alien invasion game of some sort. She turned to explain the controls to Catra when she noticed that - "Your name tag is She-Ra!"

Adora turned pink, and said defensively, "What? Our five year old selves came up with some great names!" They both laughed, and Catra continued ribbing Adora about the name throughout the game.

They played long through the night, and fell asleep on the couch together, waking up with their limbs entangled and smiles on their faces.

Chapter End Notes

Summary: Catra tells Adora about how Shadow Weaver abused her, specifically when Adora left for the final time and Shadow Weaver left her in the basement and hit/tazed her.

You know those stun batons? Yeah those are basically tasers. And the week in the basement is supposed to kind of mirror when she was locked up in the Fright Zone. Unlocking trauma through cuddles and wine, best way to go /j.

ON A DIFFERENT NOTE: I am so excited for MCC, which is kind of sad but whatever. I plan on watching Foolish and/or Ranboo bc I am queer and mentally ill. I also finally got a therapist so hopefully I will eventually only be queer. Have a great day everyone!

Fuck Yeah Baby Seals!

Chapter Notes

> Hey! What a chapter the last one was! I would say it's all uphill from there, but it's not :D. TW for them arguing and Catra yelling? I guess? IDK lmk if I need to be more specific with any of my warnings, I'm never sure exactly what to warn for.
>
> Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Hey, Adora!" Catra came bouncing into Adora's office and into one of the chairs on the other side of her desk. She was grinning almost maniacally, and her hands were flapping everywhere.

"Hey, Catra! What's up?" Adora grinned back at Catra. Ever since the first night Catra came to her apartment, the two of them had been almost inseparable. Catra just lounging on her couch or cooking at her stove was now a common sight, and Adora loved every minute of it.

"Well, I mean, I should probably start with work stuff, huh. Um . . . . Oh! The exhibit is going along great; construction should be done in like the next week or two, and then after final preparations the otters should be coming! You did all the paperwork for that, right?" Catra looked at Adora with big owlish eyes, which Adora found hard to look away from.

"Yep, it was completed a couple days ago. Meant to send you an email but I forgot," responded Adora. Catra hummed and nodded, and continued looking all around the room and shifting in her seat. "Alright, now what's *really got you excited?"*

Catra looked Adora in the eyes with the most excitement she thinks she's seen in a while. "There are seals gathered where we usually sit! And like, no one has seen them yet and our bench is

open so I think we should go and watch them because they are really cute and I think I saw a baby or two and they are just so fucking cute Adora!" said Catra breathlessly, who by the end of her mini speech was bouncing up and down in her seat.

"Well, why didn't you say that first! Come on, let's go!" Adora exclaimed, and put away her stuff as she stood up. Glancing upwards, she saw Catra look slightly worried, and asked with concern, "What's wrong, Catra?"

Catra bit her lip - which Adora found really cute, actually - and asked, "Don't you have work to do? I don't want to get you in trouble, I mean I'm on break but I know you may not be and . . ."

"Catra, it's fine. I was about to go on break too, and besides, Razz almost never gets mad at me. Stop worrying! We have baby seals to see, right?" Catra grinned, and they both went rushing out the door, down the hallway, and through the entrance to burst outside and sprint to their bench.

They went to the railing and laughed and pointed out the different seals, exclaiming whenever one of the babies did something extra cute. After a while, they settled down on their bench and leaned against each other, gazing out at the various seals. Well, Catra was. Adora found she couldn't tear her eyes away from Catra's glowing smile. Leaning against Catra, Adora felt more at home than she had in years.

With that came growing guilt. Ever since they had reconnected, Adora had had a nagging feeling of remorse and regret. Especially after that one night, Adora felt awful about leaving Catra when she did, and how she did. She still remembers how they had argued until they had screamed at each other and the other kids hid in their beds. How Catra had stormed off, close to tears, and Adora was left in the room, tears flowing freely. How she had packed her bag with the other kids silently watching, how she had opened the window and hopped out, not looking back.

Why had she never considered how Catra would've been affected? How could she have left her at such a pivotal moment?

Tears started to prick at Adora's eyes, which she tried to discreetly blink away. Catra still noticed, however, and she turned to look at Adora with concern. "What's wrong, Adora?"

"Nothing, I just . . ." Adora waved her outer hand around, as she was firmly the little spoon and her hand was too far nudged into Catra to move around. She considered dropping the subject, but she knew that the guilt would only get worse. She had to tell someone, and maybe Catra would understand. "I feel guilty."

"Adora, you know I don't blame you for leaving anymore, right? There was nothing you could have done," soothed Catra, who started rubbing Adora's back gently.

She scooched away, as much as it pained her. Adora couldn't accept the kindness of comfort. Not yet. "No, there was something I could have done."

"Adora -"

"No, Catra! There was. Just let me talk. Please?" Adora pleaded with Catra, who was looking at her with confusion and worry. She nodded, and Adora took a deep breath. What she was about to say had the potential to change their relationship forever, and not for the better. But, she had to. "When I ran away, I went to Glimmer's, right?" Catra nodded. "Well, Glimmer's mom - my adoptive mom - is - well, was - Angella. My dad's name is Micah."

Catra's face slowly dawned with recognition as she asked, "Wait, like the late mayor? Mayor Angella and her husband Micah? Those were your adoptive parents?" Adora closed her eyes and nodded as a single tear rolled down her cheek. Catra's voice got higher as she continued, "So that means. That means when you left, and got adopted, and moved, and had a normal life. The entire time me and the others were indoctrinated and abused by Shadow Weaver. The entire time, your parents could have stopped it? Your

adoptive parents, one of them being the fucking mayor, could have, oh, I don't know. Pulled some strings, got her investigated, ADOPTED us? Got her disqualified as a suitable foster parent, something?"

"Yes," sobbed Adora.

Catra stood. "But, instead, you just played house with them? Did they even know there were other kids there, or were you too fucking self centered to care?"

"Catra, no, I didn't know-" Adora stood up too, reaching out to Catra as she turned away.

"Fuck that, Adora!" Catra gave a hysterical laugh and ran her hand through her hair. "You weren't an idiot! What, you thought all those bruises, all those nights crying, were because I was fucking clumsy?"

"Catra, please, I-"

"No, Adora, I just," Catra walked a few steps away. "I just can't right now." They stood in silence for a second, Adora watching Catra's turned back as she breathed deeply.

**RING, RING* They both jumped as Catra's phone suddenly went off. She pulled it out, and pressed answer, saying, "Hey Scorpia, what's up." Adora heard muffled talking, made harder to hear as it sounded like whoever was on the other side - she was pretty sure it was one of Catra's roommates - was crying. "Oh. OK. Thanks for letting me know, I guess."*

Catra hung up, and put her phone back in her suit. Adora opened her mouth to ask what the call was about, when Catra dropped to her knees. Adora cried out, rushing to Catra. She was staring straight ahead, and said in an emotionless voice: "Shadow Weaver is dead."

Chapter End Notes

Hahahaha what a development who could've guessed this would happen hahaha! This is the only death to happen in this fic tbh so yeah. Both of their emotions are about to go haywire :D. Plus Catra was already upset so I wonder what will happen. I mean I know but you guys don't. L. /lh

On a different note, I watched Foolish for mcc (who is still streaming rn), and gotta say I enjoyed it. I'm also going to see the new Thor movie tonight, so I'm excited. Have a great day everyone!

Grief

Chapter Notes

> Hello! I did not read this all the way through bc I have another important test tomorrow that I am freaking out over. But! I deliver with content. CWs for grieving and more swearing than usual.
>
> Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Catra, I would love it if you said what you were feeling. Maybe start with when you got the call?" Will was probably making one of his concerned faces, the ones Catra hated. But she didn't know, because she was resolutely staring at the rug, trying to trace the patterns on the carpet. God, she hated that carpet. Was awful when she felt it - they had floor sessions sometimes, when they were doing hard stuff.

"Catra, please. You won't feel better if you block yourself off from those who care for you," pleaded Will. She had gotten a mandatory three days off, and since the call was on a Thursday, she was having the funeral on Sunday so that she could drown her sorrows and not have to go to work the next day. Razz had given her a hug, and said that she could take as many days as she wanted. Razz was in charge of her hours as long as she worked at the aquarium. She wish she hadn't gotten any days off.

Catra knew that if she didn't want to say anything, she could spend this entire hour in silence, and Will would let her. He was considerate that way. She hated it. She wanted someone to yell at her, to hit her. To get her out of this listless and depressive state. She knew Scorpia and Entrapta were worried, because she hadn't said a word since telling Adora on the pier. God, that felt like forever ago. Anyways, she could be a bitch and not say anything, but that would be wasting money. So, she decided to be truthful.

“Honestly, Willy boy, I don’t give a shit,” Catra snarked.

“Well, not my favorite opening, but I’ll take it. Why are you apathetic to the idea of not getting better?” Dammit, she hated when he asked good questions.

She thought for a bit. Although she didn’t want to be here, she knew he was just trying to be kind and help. And as much as she griped, she did appreciate Will. So, she tried. “I guess it just seems pointless, you know? Have I really gotten better if I’m so fucking sad about my abuser dying? I haven’t been this depressed since Ad - she left, and even then I wasn’t this bad. Who cries about their shit mom dying?”

Will hummed, and he let the silence drag on. Somehow, he knew that wasn’t all that was on her mind. Fuck, how do they know these things? “Alright, and maybe I feel bad about Adora. We got into a fight because her mom had the power to get me to leave Shadow Weaver, and she did jack shit! But her face when I told her . . . . I wish she was with me, but I also wish she would never see me again, you know?” He probably did not know, but he could deal. That was how their thing worked: she said incomprehensible and out of pocket things, and he somehow understood and gave her solutions or whatever she needed.

“Well, let’s see. I have ideas for both of your problems. Do you want to hear them, or do you want to vent some more?”

“Give me what you got, captain.”

“Oh, I like that captain title. We should keep that.”

“Don’t count on it.”

“Fine, fine. So, grieving Shadow Weaver. You’re right, she was an asshole. She hurt you, manipulated you, and made you do terrible things. But at the end of the day, she was your mother figure. She raised you, and unfortunately, human minds form strong connections with the people they are raised around. She gave you enough comfort that despite the pain, some part of you loved her.

Plus, she was the only other person who was there for your trauma. Yes, she was the one administering it, but she was still there. You were forced to bond with her. And maybe part of your sorrow is that the only person who knows the extent of what you went through is gone. Worse, they were the one to do it all, and you never got to confront her for it. So, your grief makes sense for all of those reasons. And above all that, a family member died. You are going to feel grief. None of what you are feeling is unnatural or means that you aren't better. It's natural, and it's ok. You deserve to feel what you are going to feel." Will gave her a kind smile, and Catra felt tears start to form. Fuck, why was he so good at his job?

"And then, Adora. You also have a right to be angry at her. I don't know that full story, but you seem to have a good reason to be upset. But do you know the full story? Because from what you have told me about Adora, she never seemed like the kind of person to willingly leave you alone in such an awful position." Catra cocked her head, and thought about it. She guessed that she never let Adora finish what she was saying.

"Maybe she did have a reason, but it still hurts," responded Catra.

"Yes, I'm sure it does. You have a right to be hurt, just as much as Adora has a right to be heard. You were both in a tough spot. Talk to her. Figure out the whole story, and then see where you are. If you are still angry and upset, we can talk about it. If you're not, we can talk about it. No matter what, I am here for you, as well as your friend. You are not alone, Catra. I promise."

—

You are not alone, Catra. I promise. That phrase had been ringing through her head ever since she had left her appointment. She was at home now, writing up an email to invite everyone to Shadow Weaver's funeral in the kitchen. For some reason, she had been left in charge. She had just finished up the body of the email, and was now choosing who to send it to.

Once some of the kids had turned eighteen, those lucky few had moved out and experienced the real world, realizing they were part of a cult. Those people then proceeded to adopt as many of the other fosters as they could and get them out, while also trying to get the police to realize what Shadow Weaver had been doing. It eventually worked, which is why Shadow Weaver had died in a prison cell in the city. They all hardly talked anymore, because everyone was trying to move on. This would be the first "family" reunion in years if everyone decided to come. Catra didn't expect it.

"Let's see . . . Lonnie, Rogelio . . . I guess I'll have to invite Kyle . . ." Catra muttered to herself, searching for everyone's emails. Scorpia walked in, and clamped her arms around Catra from the back of the chair. She was the first person to have left Shadow Weaver, and had buffed up to protect the rest of the kids when need be. They all hated feeling weak.

They were all in mourning, Scorpia included. Even Entrapta, whom Catra had kidnapped when she was younger. What a way to meet. Thankfully, she had forgiven Catra, and they had become good friends, especially when they both left the Horde.

"Are you going to invite Adora, Cat?" asked Scorpia, whose voice rumbled against Catra's back.

"Yeah, I should. It'll be weird, though."

"Weird how?"

"We got into a fight right before you called me."

"Oh. Sorry."

"It's ok." Catra leaned back against Scorpia, letting out a deep breath. "Your work let you take Monday off?"

"Yeah, if I work a double shift Wednesday."

"That stinks."

“Yeah.” They sat in silence, as Catra stared at the foreboding “To:” line. She quickly typed Adora’s email into the bar - she had it memorized for some reason - and hit send, covering her face up with her hands as she did so.

“Want to cuddle on the couch and rewatch The Good Place?” asked Scorpia. Catra smiled. Somehow, Scorpia always knew how to make Catra happier.

“Yeah, let’s do it.”

Chapter End Notes

Therapy!! Yay!! Also Scorpia, the beloved. Not much else to say, so I hope everyone enjoyed, and everyone has a great day.

Oh! I am also almost done with a oneshot, so hopefully it will be uploaded soon. :)

No Weddings and A Funeral

Chapter Notes

> Heyo!! I passed my test yesterday but now the systems to confirm it are all down so it means jackshit right now :D. But have no fear, your update is here. CWs for grieving in general and swearing.
>
> Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Today was the day of the funeral. When she had got Catra's email, she had gotten excited until she had read the subject line. She thought it had been Catra trying to reach out. It wasn't.

Adora stood in front of her mirror in a black dress. It wasn't fancy, reaching just below her knees and cinched at the waist. She had a black flower in her hair, and some eyeliner. When she had applied it, it had reminded her of Catra. She had to reapply it after getting rid of the tear stains the first try had left behind. She looked at herself in the mirror, trying to avoid crying again. She was pretty sure she was mostly crying because of her ruined relationship with Catra. Despite how much she loved Bow and Glimmer, they never truly understood - or knew - what she had gone through. Catra had understood her. Now she was gone, because Adora was an idiot.

Clutching her purse, she took the elevator down to the garage and got her car. Every few minutes she had to take a moment to collect herself. She was pretty sure crying while crying counted as distracted driving.

She arrived at the church twenty minutes early, and found a pew near the back. Bow and Glimmer were on their way, but were probably going to be late. Still, she needed the emotional support. She saw a few familiar faces, like Lonnie and Kylie. Rogelio was

probably around here somewhere, then. They saw her looking and waved, and Adora responded with a small wave of her own.

Catra had just been spotted on the other side of the church when Adora was suddenly ambushed by two people sitting on either side of her and enveloping her in a crushing hug. "Bow! Glimmer! You're here!" exclaimed Adora.

"Of course we are!" responded Bow.

"What, you thought we wouldn't come? How rude!" said Glimmer in mock offense.

"No, no, I thought you'd come. Just twenty minutes late, not twenty minutes early!" At that, they all started talking over each other and arguing, intermediately laughing. They eventually quieted down as they got a few stares, and they started whispering.

Catra walked by as they were doing so, and Adora stopped what she had been saying in favor of watching Catra with mournful eyes. Bow and Glimmer noticed and whipped around to watch Catra go by. "Guys! Don't be so obvious, geez!"

But they both ignored her in favor of talking over each other in barley quiet whispers.

"Wait is that Catra-"

"I feel like I recognize her-"

"Why were you looking at her like that, you looked lovesick or something-"

"She's kind of hot, not gonna lie-"

"Glimmer!" said Bow and Adora at the same time, looking at her with mouths agape.

Glimmer looked at both of them and grinned. “What, I can’t appreciate beauty? Don’t worry, Bow, I still think you’re pretty. And no worries, Adora, I’m not going to move in on your girl.”

This time, Adora and Bow started talking over each other.

“You think I’m pretty? Babe, that’s kind of embarrassing for you-”

“You guys, I’m not lovesick, and Catra’s not “my girl”, shut up-”

But they both got shut up as the music started, and everyone in the church stood up. The three of them stood as well, Bow and Glimmer suddenly gripping Adora’s hands tight. She was grateful for that, as the procession started and Shadow Weaver’s coffin was carried down the aisle.

The whole funeral was painful, but thankfully not religious. Shadow Weaver didn’t believe in religion, and so neither did any of her kids. Adora thought Catra probably chose this church out of spite, although it was really pretty too. The procession went outside afterward, and they all gathered around to watch her coffin being lowered. The priest offered everyone a chance to throw in dirt. No one stepped forward.

It was now just the foster kids at the gravestone. Everyone else had left - Bo and Glimmer were waiting in their car, and said to “take all the time you need”.

After twenty minutes, she told them to just go home, and that she would talk to them later.

After an hour, it was raining, and she and Catra were the only two left at the grave. They were sitting on opposite sides - Adora on the left, Catra on the right. They hadn’t said a word, or even glanced at each other.

Adora couldn’t bear it. “Catra, I want to talk, and I want you to listen. You don’t have to say anything, I just want you to listen. Please, if you’ve listened to nothing else, I need you to listen to this.” Catra stayed silent, and Adora took that as an affirmative. “I

never got to explain why my parents didn’t help you. Didn’t help any of you. And I want to explain. Now.

“When I got to Glimmer’s, I was dazed, and tired. They took me in, and gave me food, clothes, and a bed. They were kind, and comforting, and I was so tired, Catra. I had to walk for miles to get to them. I stayed there, recuperating for a few days. They never asked where I came from, and honestly? I didn’t want to tell them. You know how people react when you say you're a foster kid. I didn’t want them to take me back. I didn’t trust them yet.

“Then Shadow Weaver started following me. They didn’t notice, but Glimmer did. She begged me to tell her parents, but I couldn’t. I knew you were still there, I knew that I was still in danger, but I couldn’t do it. I was terrified they’d send me back, and everything would be worse. But when she broke in, I had to tell them. They were angry, at first, but soon understood. When they did, they realized that the system would find out soon, so they had to act fast. They fought tooth and nail to adopt me. They did, eventually, but couldn’t publicize it for my safety - probably why you never found out.

“I begged them to adopt you, to help the others, but they couldn’t. It was hard enough getting me while also keeping me protected from the Horde, and they said they didn’t want to risk my safety by angering the Horde any more. Looking back, I can see how they could’ve done more. How they were afraid, and didn’t know what to do, so they did nothing. But back then, I didn’t feel like I could fight back. I was worried if I did, they would react like Shadow Weaver would. Now I know they wouldn’t, but thirteen year old me didn’t. So I accepted it, and had to leave you. I hated myself for it, believe me, I did. But I had no other choice.” They both sat in silence, as Catra took it in and Adora tried to compose herself. She was pretty sure her makeup was ruined. “I’m so fucking sorry, Catra.”

Adora buried her face in her knees and started sobbing, her hair and dress soaked from the pouring rain. She felt a weight on her,

and sobbed even harder as Catra stroked her hair. They sat like that for a while, Catra awkwardly hugging Adora as she sat and cried.

Catra whispered, “Hey, want to go to my apartment?” Adora nodded, and they stayed there together for a little while longer.

There are moments in life that feel infinite. As Adora sat in the rain, hugged by a childhood friend, grieving her past, she swore time froze.

Chapter End Notes

> Adora? Opening up? What magical world is this? Also apologies for shorter chapter but we are nearing the end o7.
>
> The oneshot is almost done!! I just have to write a bit more and then read over and then it's good. Also on an unrelated note tell me why writing romance is harder than writing a death scene. FINALLY there is a chance I will write a Stranger Things fic bc Byler brainrot but that won't happen for a while due to a trip I'm going on and school starting again soon. But! It may happen.
>
> Ok bye everyone, have a great day! :)

Cuddles (and more mac and cheese)

Chapter Notes

> Hey guys! I almost forgot to post this chapter bc of stressing about a trip lol. Also it's so fucking hot I'm dying. TWs are refrenced emotional abuse and minor physical abuse. Also a lot of crying.
>
> Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When she had invited Adora over, she had forgotten just how messy she had left her apartment. It was a bit embarrassing, but she was grieving, ok? That totally excuses the clothes strewn around the living room and the many dishes in the sink. Yep.

She wasn't sure what Adora thought about her apartment, but she wasn't sure Adora was thinking anyways. Adora still seemed dazed from her crying session at the cemetery, and probably wasn't thinking about much. Catra went to her kitchen to pull out some boxed mac and cheese, a dish they both loved when they were younger. It was a bit past lunch time, but they were both wet and hungry, so who cares.

Adora sat stiffly on one of the stools at the counter as Catra prepared the box to go into the microwave, praying it wouldn't go out again. She grabbed a bowl and two forks, and they waited in silence for the mac and cheese to finish. It did with a ding, and Catra said, "Whelp. Want to eat on the couch?" Adora nodded numbly and walked over to the couch as Catra split the mac and cheese and put half in the bowl. She usually ate from the box.

Catra walked over to the couch to see that Adora was just standing there, looking at the couch without seeming to process it. Putting down the box and bowl on the couch, she plopped down on the couch. She pulled Adora down next to her, and put the bowl in her lap as she pulled her close.

Catra could tell that Adora wasn't ready to talk, so she cast her mind back and said, "Remember when we used to play princess and knight? One of us being the princess, stuck in a tower or prison. The other one would be the knight and fight dragons, or robots, or whatever, trying to save the other. The princess cheering on, or flirting, and when she was saved, we would kiss and get married. Kind of gay, now that I think on it. We should have known then." Adora giggled, and Catra smiled, pushing on. "And when we read that book on women heroes, we would make the princess save the knight. Fighting random things, becoming like, really overpowered. I think I was the best princess, to be honest."

"Please, no one could beat Shera," responded Adora.

"Oh come on, I won a lot, from what I remember. That's just what cat powers do."

"All I remember is you running away a lot."

"Hmm, agree to disagree, then," Catra said, smiling. They ate their mac and cheese, reminiscing on the good times they had together, carefully tiptoeing past the bad parts. Well, for aso, long as they could.

"And then, and then," said Catra, struggling to speak through her laughter, "then I jumped from the tree, claiming I could land on my feet, because that's what cats did. I'm pretty sure I got a twisted ankle!" Catra chuckled, then frowned as Adora's face turned somber. "What's wrong?"

"Nothing."

"Bro. I sobbed to you on your couch about my trauma. Now it's your turn!" joked Catra. Adora only gave a small smile, and Catra smiled gently at her. "Seriously. It's ok. You can tell me anything."

Adora looked ahead, and leaned heavily against Catra. "When that happened, and the others bandaged your foot, Shadow Weaver took me to our room and yelled at me. Told me I was

irresponsible, and that she expected better. That she didn't - she didn’t want to care for broken things, and I knew that. She accused me of making you jump, so that Shadow Weaver would get rid of you. I can’t count how many times she threatened your safety for my obedience. She would tell me I was worthless, and then give me a hug telling me how she loved me despite my many flaws.

“Whenever I did something well, she would always find a way to make me feel bad about it, that I didn’t deserve it. She would only give me a compliment if it hurt someone else, or if I was really upset. When I came back the first time I ran, she yelled at me for so long. Calling me a bitch, and selfish, and that. That she wished I hadn’t come back, for all the trouble I caused. That I was ungrateful for all she had done, and I didn't care about you all. I left because she hit me.”

“Wait, what?” Catra looked at Adora in shock, who was still just staring at the opposite wall.

“It was the day I left for good. She was yelling at me again for being an idiot, or something, and I spoke back. I never had before, I always let her just talk until she got tired. But I had seen Glimmer with her mom, and thought. Well, I thought that maybe we could have a relationship like they did, you know? So I stood up for myself, and she slapped me and told me to shut up. She hugged me and apologized, but my mind had been made up.” When Adora had come to her, begging Catra to leave with her, she had never told her why she was so eager to leave. Catra didn’t understand that life could be better than it was, and Adora was being stubborn about why she wanted to leave. It’s why she had argued. It’s why they had been separated for years. They were both being abused, but they were both too ashamed and too young to tell each other.

Somehow, Catra pulled Adora even closer to her, and whispered, “I’m so sorry, Adora.” Adora finally broke her staring contest with the wall, and tucked her head under Catra’s.

"It was never as bad as you had, though. It's so stupid," whispered Adora back, tears running down her face.

Catra also started tearing up, and whispered, "Trauma and abuse isn't a competition, Adora. What hurts, hurts. Abuse is abuse. And I'm so sorry you had to go through all that alone."

Catra's shirt was soaked with Adora's tears, but she couldn't give less of a shit. They sat and cried together, the only sounds being their heavy breathes and the occasional honk and siren outside. Eventually, Adora lifted her head, and said, "That thing about trauma was really insightful. How'd you come up with that one?"

"You can thank Will, actually," responded Catra, still speaking gently. Boy, the session where that had been told to her was a rough one. It was definitely a floor discussion. Suddenly, she remembered how Will told her to encourage good thoughts about therapy, and said, "Therapy's good for that stuff."

Adora hummed, and Catra hoped that was a good sign. Oh, shit, she thought, as she suddenly remembered how Will suggested she apologize to Adora for how she used to treat her. To be honest, she didn't always follow through on therapy homework, because she generally forgot everything once she left the session. But now was a better time than ever, she guessed.

"Hey Adora?" Catra asked. Adora hummed. "I'm sorry for being an asshole sometimes when we were younger. I know we were just kids, and a lot of what I did was based off the abuse I was experiencing, leading me to need to express my feelings in other ways - Will helped with that realization, if you couldn't tell - but I still was cruel to you at times when we were kids, and when you were going through tough times, too. And don't just say it's ok, because it's not. It's something we need to work on working through. But I am so genuinely sorry, Adora. I promise."

"I believe you, Catra. I believe you," whispered Adora back. With all said that truly needed to be said, they both put their legs on the couch and cuddled, talking about everything and nothing.

And if Scorpia and Entrapta have pictures of them sleeping on the couch, that’s no one’s business but their own.

Chapter End Notes

> Wow! Cuddles! Hope you all enjoyed, and we are in the final few chapters. For the next chapter on Sunday, I'm not sure I will be able to post it due to my trip and not having my computer. But I will try my hardest, and if worse comes to worst I will post it Monday instead.
>
> Have a great day!

Opening Day

Chapter Notes

> Hey! Posting this while on a trip, so hopefully it goes well! Enjoy this chapter :)
>
> Only TW is some slight self-hatred about her body and some insecurities from Adora.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She finally started therapy. Yeah, yeah, clap everyone. Collect your bets. After her heart to heart with Catra, she realized that she was maybe more affected from her childhood than she realized. Maybe. So she found a therapist near her and is seeing her every Saturday. Catra suggested that day, because apparently you want time to recover after a tough session. After a few weeks with Mara, she understands what she meant.

Catra was also insanely jealous that Adora got a therapist, like, immediately while looking. Good luck, she guessed. Really good luck, because Mara has been absolutely amazing. Apparently, looking in the mirror and fantasizing about violently changing her body is not normal and is in fact because Shadow Weaver criticized her body so much. Who knew!

In all seriousness, Adora has never felt happier while also being terrified. Because, as she told Mara, there is a chance everything she has with Catra will come crashing down soon. The exhibit is done and opening today, which means that Catra now has no real reason to hang with Adora. And even though she knows (ok, Mara knew, and told her) that Catra is genuinely friends with her, and work friends don't usually come over to your house all the time, she is still scared Catra will disappear after all this. That Adora messed up, somehow, and Catra can't wait to drop her.

These are the thoughts that are running through her head as she gets ready in her office to lead the first guests through the otter

exhibit. Bow and Glimmer are here for it, and so are some of Catra's friends - her roommates, whom she met the day of Shadow Weaver's funeral. Lonnie and the others might even come; after the funeral, all the foster kids kind of reconnected and have been trying to get to know each other again. Catra joked that it was like The Umbrella Academy, prompting Adora to look at her in confusion, prompting Catra and her roommates to sit Adora down and do a binge watch with them.

Anyways, she was really nervous. Razz might also be coming, even in her old age. Although, she's always been old to Adora. Kind of like how Cher never seems to age. That's beside the point. Razz has been like a second mother to Adora, and Adora always seeks her approval. Huh. Is that trauma based? Maybe she should tell Mara at the next session.

"Adora." At the sound of her name, Adora looked up quickly to see Catra leaning against her door. She was wearing the same suit she had worn the first day she worked at the aquarium, and it gave Adora butterflies. Catra looked beautiful. "*Adora. Are you coming or not? The exhibit opens in, like, ten minutes. I did not work for months on this for you to be late," teased Catra, smiling. Adora smiled nervously back, and Catra said, "Hey, you got this. You've been so excited for this, you know literally everything about this project. You're going to be great. And, if you really fuck it up, we could go get ice cream after. I mean we can do that anyways, I guess." Even though that wasn't what she was nervous about, she still felt better.*

"Yay, pity ice cream. I can't wait!" Adora stood and grinned at Catra, who flushed a bit.

"You know what I meant. Come on, let's gooo," whined Catra, smiling at Adora and pulling at her out the door and partly down the hallway. Adora laughed and took her arms back, and they went on their way to the exhibit. Past the entrance, where they awkwardly reunited after over a decade. Past the jellyfish exhibit, where they had their first really deep talk. All the way to the previously closed off entrance to the thing they had worked hard

on for all this time. The exhibit that had drawn the two of them together. That had made them both better people. It was finished, and Adora could hear otters chittering inside, barely heard over the murmuring of the crowd gathered.

She avoided looking at any of the crowd, terrified of counting how many people she would be speaking in front of. Getting to the front, Adora turned and looked out over the room, trying to find a spot to look at that made it look like she was actually looking at the crowd. Heterochromiac eyes caught her attention, and Adora found that she was suddenly locking eyes with Catra. She must've split off at some point while Adora was freaking out, and was at the back of the crowd, smiling at Adora.

Adora kept her eyes on Catra as she said her speech. "Welcome, everyone, to Madame Razz's Magnificent Aquarium, where you too can feel like a mermaid!" She paused for the applause which Catra joined in with a slow clap. Adora swallowed down a laugh, and continued, "Today is the start of a new era for the MRMA! Our staff has been working tirelessly to create a beautiful exhibit, which is comfortable for the inhabitants and made for easy viewing by our lovely community! And, of course, none of this could have been made possible if it weren't for the lovely head of design and installation, Elizabeth!" She clapped in the direction of Catra, and everyone turned to her and clapped. Catra gave a strained smile, and when everyone turned back to Adora, gave her a middle finger. Adora smiled, and said, "Finally, I of course thank Madame Razz for her continued dedication to educate the public about marine life while also keeping all the animals safe, healthy, and happy. And with no further ado," she paused as Trevor and Joyce next to her raised the banner and scissors respectively, "welcome to Madame Razz's Otter Exhibit!" Everyone clapped and cheered as Joyce cut the banner, and the people streamed in.

Joyce gave her a pat on the shoulder and walked off, presumably back to her office. Trevor gave her a nervous thumbs up, which she reciprocated, and then walked inside the exhibit to help the visitors.

“Great job, Dora!” Spinneralla said, leaning on her shoulder.

“Yeah, great job hun.” Netossa was on the other side of her wife, both of them smiling wide at Adora.

“Thanks, guys,” responded Adora, who was currently looking for Catra in the crowd.

They saw her do it, and Netossa grinned mischievously and said, “You’re right, babe. She really is whipped for Elizabeth.”

“Netossa!” Both of them exclaimed, probably for different reasons. Spinneralla was smiling a bit too wide as Adora’s face grew red.

“I know, right? Me and Bow have bets on if stuff will happen,” said Glimmer, who had just come up as that exchange happened. Bow gave Adora a hug, and nodded along.

“Guysss,” whined Adora, her face becoming an even brighter red.

“Are we talking about Adora and Catra? Oh, get in line. Rog and Kyle and I have had a bet going for a looong time. Since we were kids.” Adora startled at the addition of another voice, and turned to see Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio standing behind Adora. They were smiling, and Adora awkwardly smiled back.

“You guys, it’s rude to gossip about crushes. Especially when the person is dumb as bricks and doesn’t realize it yet,” joined in Bow, and everyone around her laughed. Adora groaned, and wished for a hole to open up and swallow her whole. Her eye caught on Catra on the other side of the room, talking to Razz. Catra waved and smiled, and Adora did it back, only for everyone around her to laugh heartily.

Razz and Catra walked over, and the circle of people widened to allow them in. “Alright, alright. Stop torturing my favorite employee and go enjoy the exhibit,” said Razz to the mock hurt from Spin and Netossa. Everyone started moving to the exhibit, but Razz stopped Adora with a gentle hand on her shoulder. “Not you, my dear. I want to speak with you for a minute.”

They walked through the aquarium and went outside, going to Adora and Catra's bench. They sat, and stared off to the horizon for a bit, enjoying the sounds of seagulls and waves.

"So, how's it going?" asked Razz, in her old wavering voice.

"It's going great. I mean, the otter exhibit is obviously really popular, and I've started therapy - although you already knew that, I guess - oh, I think business this summer will be great, I mean I know that's not my job but I've done the numbers and-"

"My dear," interrupted Razz, "you know I appreciate all you've done for MRMA. But you know what I meant. How is it going?"

Adora sighed. "I'm nervous for when Catra leaves."

"Why?"

"Because . . ." Adora looked at Razz. "Because what if she leaves? Like, I know she's going to, but what if she also leaves me? What if she doesn't want to talk anymore? What if-"

"My dear, "what if"s do no one any good, and you know that. Let me tell you something. Do you know what she and I were discussing earlier?"

"No. What?"

"We were discussing her future. And I believe she mentioned your name at least ten times," siad Razz, finally looking into Adora's eyes. "I do not know the future. No one knows for sure. But what I do know, my dear, is that she does not plan on leaving you any time soon."

Adora looked at Razz in shock as the old woman turned back to look out over the water. She thought that was the end of the conversation, until Razz added, "Additionally, my dear. I believe that if you were to tell her how you truly feel, you will find many rewards in your future."

With that, Razz stood and walked to the aquarium, leaving Adora on the bench shocked, hopeful, and honestly? A little confused.

Chapter End Notes

MARA MY LOVE. Also, Adora maybe realizing feels? :o Idk one chapter left let's find out. It is a hc of mine that Adora has body dysmorphia bc of both pressures from the Horde and bc of Shera being a different body shape, and seeing how many people adore and idealize Shera. Those types of reactions to Shera compared to what Adora gets normally are so different there is definitely some self-hatred there, and no I am not projecting how dare you /j. It is not a tag bc it is one or two lines.

Also why did no one tell me the creators of various aroace flags are so problematic?? Like idk which one is right? Anyways have a great day.

It’s Going Swimmingly

Chapter Notes

> Hey hey hey!! Last chapter wow!! Can you believe I almost forgot to post this lol. I am back from my trip, and while it was fun, I am so overstimulated from it all I want zero social interaction for the next week. Alas, I am going on yet another trip. Also guess who has an appointment with a new therapist tomorrow. *tongue sticking out emoji bc idk how to put emojis here*
>
> Get ready for gay Catra.
>
> No TWs for this chapter, and I hope you all enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The day was one of the busiest ones Catra had ever experienced. It felt like thousands of people were streaming in and out of the exhibit. Every once and a while, a visitor complimented her, and instead of feeling weirded out, Catra felt satisfaction.

When Adora came back in from her talk with Razz, she looked a bit shell shocked, and avoided Catra’s gaze. It gave Catra anxious knots, which she tried to get rid of by catching up with Lonnie and the others and getting to know Spinderella and Netossa better.

It did not help.

As it got darker, the crowd thankfully thinned out, and soon it was just a few guests milling about. One of them was Glimmer, who was coming up to Catra with a determined look on her face. Catra looked around, trying to find an exit, but Glimmer caught up before she could flee.

“Elizabeth, is it?” asked Glimmer, giving a look of skepticism.

"Uh, I prefer Catra, actually. Elizabeth is my government name, but, you know," responded Catra, twisting her hands awkwardly.

"Alright, Catra. I have something to say to you, and you are *not going to interrupt me. I know I look different, so you probably haven't realized yet, but I was the girl you met in jail that one time." Catra opened her mouth in shock. She had thought she had recongnized Glimmer from somewhere, but when she was in fucking jail? Why was she even arrested? Glimmer barreled on. "I believe the same thing I did then: you're dangerous, but have a good heart, and I think you can do good things. So listen up. Adora is borderline in love with you, and I'm not about to see her heart broken because you can't figure out your own feelings. So, figure out if you like her or not, and if I find out you hurt her in any way, shape, or form, I swear to whoever you believe in that you will rue the day. Understand?" Catra stared at Glimmer with wide eyes, trying to take it all in. Adora likes her? Since when? Why?*

Bow had come up to them while Glimmer was speaking, and wrapped an arm around Glimmer. "That's a bit extreme, but I agree. Just, be kind to her, ok? She's like my sister. Plus, I think you're a good person. It makes sense why she likes you so much." With that earth shattering news, the two of them walked away, talking to each other quietly. She watched as they said goodbye to Adora and walked out the door.

If she thought about it, it made sense. The amount of times she was mesmerized by Adora's face, or figure, or her muscles . . . damn, they were amazing. The butterflies she got sometimes when they got close together, the jealousy she had when Adora talked about her first girlfriend. The absolute want she sometimes has for Adora's embrace, how she felt at home in her arms.

Shit. She was in love with Adora.

By the time the aquarium closed, Catra was fully freaking out. She was leaving today, what the hell was she supposed to say? Oh, hey, I'm leaving now. By the way I'm in love with you and

probably have been since childhood. Bye for forever! Well, it wouldn't be forever, unless Bow and Glimmer were wrong and Adora didn't reciprocate her feelings. Then she might bury herself in a hole and never come out.

All these thoughts were swirling around her mind as she stood on the deck above the exhibit, watching the otters below sleep and hold hands. God, she wished she was an otter. They didn't have to worry about any of this stuff. Just float and spin.

"What are you thinking about there, Franklin?" Adora slid up next to Catra on the railing, pressing tight against Catra's side.

"Franklin?"

"Yeah, Rosalind Franklin, the chemist. Her work was robbed, it's awful."

"Oh. Nerd."

"Hey! I just respect smart women! If that makes me a nerd, so be it," stated Adora, puffing out her chest. Catra chuckled, and went back to watching the otters float. "Seriously, Catra. What's up?"

"I'm just . . . sad that I'm leaving," said Catra, leaning her head against Adora's.

"Well, you can always visit! Plus, we'll hang out a lot. Right?" asked Adora, and Catra could detect concern in her voice.

"Of course, of course! Actually, I'm thinking of starting my own company. Razz says that I'm good enough for it, and that way I could set my own hours, do what I want," said Catra. It was a new idea, but one that she loved.

"Oh, that's a great idea! I could help with the design of your logo! Although, your whole job is design . . ."

"No, I would love for you to design it! It'll be great." She looked up and stared ahead. "It's just that. Well, I'm scared of everything

changing, you know?" asked Catra.

Adora was silent for a minute, and then said, "Well, everything changes. Sometimes for the better, sometimes for the worse. We've reconnected with the other fosters, I'm going to therapy, you're starting your own company," she nudged Catra at that, and they both smiled. "Change can be good. It can be great. You just have to let it happen."

"I'm in love with you." Catra wanted to take back the words immediately, but she also knew that there was no better time (nor a time where she would have this much confidence to say it). "I think I've always been in love with you. You're just so amazing. You're strong, and beautiful, and funny, and persistent, and creative, and I just love every bit of it. Every bit of you. I understand if you don't feel the same, but I just wanted you to know. I love you, Adora."

The silence was awful. Catra couldn't tell how long they stood there, her waiting for Adora to respond (it was only two seconds).

"I love you, too. I've known it for a while, but I think I've just been denying it. But I do. You're kind, and passionate, and witty, and so fucking beautiful, Catra. God, that suit has been driving me crazy." They were standing face to face, just looking at each other.

"Kiss me, Adora. Please." Adora smiled, and closed the space between the two of them.

Kissing Adora was unlike any other woman she had kissed. It was soft, and tender, and Catra pulled Adora in at the waist as Adora cupped her face. If the silence had been forever, this was infinity. Her mind was filled with indescribable love and happiness, her only thoughts being this moment and this moment only. It was bliss.

They pulled away, and laughed. Catra looked into Adora's eyes, and kissed her again, unable to resist. She pulled away, and they grinned at each other.

"So, does this mean I get your number now?" asked Adora, and Catra hit her arm in mock anger. All this time, and they had never exchanged numbers. Ridiculous. They turned back to look at the exhibit, wrapping an arm around each other.

"You know, that kiss was just otterly perfect," whispered Adora.

"I regret everything I said."

"Hey! It was a good one!"

"It was ok."

If someone were to walk in at that moment, they would have seen two people standing and laughing, watching as the otters below them swam and slept. They would have seen them kiss each other, giddy and in love.

If someone were to walk in, they would have seen love in its most pure, happiest form.

And a lot of otters.

Chapter End Notes

Yay!! The one (1) pun I used!! Never will this lack of puns happen again, I promise o/

Ok, so. What now? I have two ideas. One is more formed, which would center around Lilith from TOH and basically be following her discovery and acceptance of herself (and will be loosely (*very loosely) based off my experiences). The other is what I've been saying forever, which would be a Byler fic. IDK how I want to do it though so we will see. BUT neither of these will be coming for at least a month, because I am going to be incredibly busy (unless something happens and I have time).*

Alright then! I hope you all have enjoyed this fic, and thank you all so much who have followed it until now. Go ahead and check out one of my other works if you want, and I hope you all have a lovely August!

EDIT: first off, I forgot a chapter title which is embarrassing- fixed, don't worry. ANYWAYS I am currently in Italy and on the flight over I watched the rest of Young Royals and I LOVE THEM SO MUCH. I have many ideas my loves. Also I read Radio Silence by Alice Oseman (heartstopper and loveless author) and once again it was amazing I loved it so much. Anyways just know that I may write a young royals fic and/or an amphibia fic sometime

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!